



P 2 4 · 3 0 C A R D S , A G E S 1 T O 6

The Bedtime Routine Cards

Thirty printable cards the child can shuffle, sort, and arrange into the bedtime order they choose. Replaces the negotiation with the structure. Two age tiers (illustration-heavy for toddlers, word-heavy for older kids), plus a parent guide that does not promise miracles.

Soothemade Notes

A SMALL APOTHECARY OF PRINTABLES · MADE SLOWLY

A note before you print

The hardest hour of parenting most days is the hour before bed. Every transition becomes a treaty. Pajamas are a hostage negotiation. The toothbrush is a deal-breaker.

This deck is not a method. It is not a “perfect bedtime in seven nights.” It is a small structural shift: the child holds the deck. The child decides the order. The order is theirs. The steps are the same.

The child is doing something for themselves, instead of being moved through a routine. That small piece of agency is, often, the thing that ends the negotiation.

Soothemade

How to print

- US Letter or A4. Cardstock if you have it.
- Six cards per page. Cut along the lines.
- Two sizes in the file: standard (3.5" × 5.5") and large (5" × 7") for younger kids.
- Punch a hole in the top-left corner. Put on a binder ring. Hang from a hook in the bathroom or bedroom.

How to introduce the deck

The first night, do this:

1. Pick a calm moment, NOT bedtime.
2. Spread out the twelve core-step cards on the floor.
3. Say: "These are the things we do before bed. Right now we kind of do them in any order, and it gets bumpy. I thought we could try something. You pick the order. I'll do whatever the cards say."
4. Let the child pick up the cards. Let them stack them. Let them ignore them.
5. End the conversation casually. "Anyway, when bedtime comes, the cards will be here."

That night:

1. Bring out the deck.
2. "Okay, pick the order."
3. They pick. You follow.

That's it.

How to use the deck on a normal night

- The child shuffles or sorts the deck.
- They pick a card. You do the thing.
- They pick the next card. You do the thing.
- All twelve core-step cards must get done. The order is theirs.

If they pick "sleep" first, gently:

"Sleep is the last card. Pick another one to start with."

If they refuse to pick, neutral:

"That's okay. I'll pick the first one. You can pick the next one."

The deck is the structure. You are the soft enforcer of "all twelve get done." Beyond that, the child runs the night.

How to use the deck on a hard night

Some nights everything is harder. Big feelings. A bad day at school. A missed nap.

On those nights, two adjustments:

Use a “tonight only” card

The child gets to add ONE "tonight only" card to the deck.

The choices are:

- ☐ Extra story (one more book than usual)
- ☐ Choose a stuffed animal (a different one from the usual)
- ☐ Pick the night light
- ☐ Eat the small snack (one card, one snack)
- ☐ Read the emotion-check card

Used sparingly, this card preserves their sense of agency on a hard night. Used every night, the magic fades.

Pull an emotion-check card

Six cards in the deck are emotion-checks. On a hard night:

"It looks like tonight is heavier. Want to pull one of the heart cards?"

The child reads (or you read) the card. You sit together for two minutes. The card does some of the talking.

Card pack one, the twelve core-step cards

Each card is printed two ways: the “illustration” version for ages 1-3 and the “word” version for ages 4-6. Use whichever fits your kid.

Card 1, Pajamas

Pajamas. The soft ones. We can do them together, or you can do them yourself.

(Illustration: A small folded pair of pajamas.)

Card 2, Teeth

Teeth time. Two minutes. We do the front, the back, the in-between, and the tongue. The timer or the song will tell us when.

(Illustration: A small toothbrush.)

Card 3, Bathroom

One last bathroom trip. Even if you don't think you need one. Just sit on the toilet for thirty seconds.

(Illustration: A small toilet.)

Card 4, Water

One sip of water before bed. Not a whole cup. One sip.

(Illustration: A small cup.)

Card 5, Story

One book. You pick. I read.

(Illustration: An open book.)

Card 6, Lights Low

Lights low time. Big light off. Lamp on. The room starts to feel like sleep.

(Illustration: A small lamp with a dim glow.)

Card 7, Snuggle

Snuggle, two minutes. Whatever shape you want. Side by side. Sitting up. Lying down. You pick.

(Illustration: Two figures sitting close.)

Card 8, Soft Song

One song. Sung soft. You pick which one.

(Illustration: A small music note.)

Card 9, One More Question

Your one bedtime question. Anything you want to ask. Just one.

(Illustration: A small question mark.)

Card 10, Animals Lined Up

Stuffed animals get tucked in. They go where they sleep. We say goodnight to each one.

(Illustration: Three small stuffed animals in a row.)

Card 11, Light Out

Lamp off. Just the night light now. Or no light. Whichever you wanted.

(Illustration: A small dark room with a tiny glow.)

Card 12, Sleep

Sleep card. The night begins. I'll see you in the morning.

(Illustration: A small crescent moon.)

Card pack two, the six “tonight only” cards

To be played sparingly. One per night, on a hard night.

Card A, Extra Story

Tonight you get one more book than usual. You pick. I read. After that, no more.

Card B, Choose A Stuffed Animal

Tonight, pick a different stuffed animal to sleep with. From any room. Even one you haven't used in a while.

Card C, Pick The Night Light

Tonight, you choose which night light. Or you choose no night light.

Card D, Small Snack

Tonight, one small snack before bed. A cracker. A small piece of fruit. Not a meal. Just a small thing.

Card E, A Walk To The Window

Tonight, before lights out, we walk to the window. We look out for two minutes. We say goodnight to whatever we see.

Card F, A Word In The Dark

Tonight, when the lights are out, you get to say one thing. Anything you want. I'll listen. Then we sleep.

Card pack three, the six emotion-check cards

For the hard nights. Pull one, or two, or none. The child can also pick which one to pull.

Card 1, A Big Feeling

Today I had a big feeling. The feeling was: _____. The grown-up listened. I am ready for sleep, or I am still figuring it out. Either is okay.

Card 2, Something I'm Worried About

Something I am worried about tomorrow is: _____. I told the grown-up. The grown-up will think about it overnight. I will sleep.

Card 3, Two Minutes To Talk

I want two minutes to talk. About anything. Not a long thing. Just two minutes. Then we sleep.

Card 4, Something That Was Good

The best thing about today was: _____. The grown-up agrees. Or the grown-up didn't know. Either way, it counts.

Card 5, A Hug

I want a big hug. The kind where the grown-up squeezes a little. Then we go to sleep.

Card 6, Just Quiet

I don't want to talk. I just want quiet. The grown-up will sit with me for two minutes without words.

Card pack four, the six choice cards

For predictability with a little agency. These can be used along with the core cards.

Card 1, You Pick The Pajamas

You pick which pajamas tonight. From the drawer that has the ones for your age.

Card 2, You Pick The Book

You pick the book for tonight. From the bookshelf. Not the screen.

Card 3, You Pick The Stuffed Animal

You pick which stuffed animal sleeps next to you tonight.

Card 4, You Pick The Song

You pick which song the grown-up sings tonight. (Or hums. The grown-up does their best.)

Card 5, You Pick The Side

You pick which side of the bed I sit on for the snuggle. Or I sit on the floor. You pick.

Card 6, You Pick The Light

You pick which light is on for the snuggle: the lamp, the night light, or just the hallway.

The parent guide

A four-page guide that goes at the front of the printed deck.

Page one, the philosophy in two sentences

The deck is not a behavior chart. It is a vocabulary and a structure. The child runs the order. You hold the structure.

Page two, on the first three nights

The first three nights might be rough. The child is testing the structure. They will pick weird orders. They may pick "sleep" first to see what you do. They may refuse to pick at all.

What to do:

- Stay neutral. Your face does not get tense.
- "Sleep is the last card. Pick another one to start with."
- "That's okay. I'll pick the first one. You can pick the next one."
- Do not pile on consequences. The deck is the structure. The structure is the consequence.

By night four or five, the child usually settles into a pattern. Often they pick the same first three cards every night. That is fine. The deck adapted to them.

Page three, on when to use the "tonight only" card

Sparingly. Once a week, maybe. The "tonight only" card works because it is rare.

If you let the child play the "tonight only" card every night, it becomes a fixed part of the routine. Now you have a longer routine, not a shorter negotiation.

A good rule: the "tonight only" card comes out when something is genuinely off. A bad day. A change in the family. A sick day. Not "every night because they ask."

Page four, on what NOT to do

- × Don't use the deck as a reward chart. ("If you do all twelve cards quietly, you get a sticker.") The deck is the routine, not a behavior program.
- × Don't take cards away as punishment. ("You don't get the snuggle card tonight because you yelled.") The cards are predictable. Predictability is the safety.
- × Don't add cards beyond what's in the deck. Twelve is the cap. More is more negotiation.
- × Don't use it on a child who is not into it. If the child rejects the deck after a week, fine. The deck is a tool, not a rule.

A small note on what bedtime is for

A page to read once, somewhere quiet.

The bedtime routine is not, mostly, about getting the child to sleep. It is about the child's body and brain learning the cues. "When these things happen, in this order, sleep is coming."

The order does not actually matter that much. The repetition does.

If you do the same cards in roughly the same way for three weeks, the body learns the pattern. The child stops fighting it because their nervous system has aligned with it.

The hour before bed becomes shorter, not because the child has stopped resisting, but because their body has stopped sounding the alarm.

The deck is one way to get there. There are others. The point is the consistency.

When this is harder than a deck can fix

A short page. Honest.

If the bedtime routine is not working after several weeks, even with structure, something else might be going on:

- The child has a sleep regression (especially around 18 months, 2 years, 3 years, age 5)
- The child has separation anxiety that needs more than a routine
- The child has a sensory or developmental need that a pediatric provider can help with
- The household has a stressor (move, new sibling, a sick relative, parental tension) that's bleeding into bedtime
- A parent's own stress is showing up at bedtime (kids are bedtime-stress detectors)

If any of those resonate, the deck won't solve it. It is still useful. It just isn't the whole answer.

When to ask for help:

- The bedtime takes more than 45 minutes for several weeks
- The child is regularly crying or terrified at bedtime, not just resistant
- You are dreading bedtime in a way that is affecting your own well-being
- You suspect a sleep disorder (insomnia, night terrors, sleepwalking that is happening often)

A pediatric provider, a pediatric sleep specialist, or a family therapist can help.

Numbers to keep

PEDIATRICIAN

Name: _____ Number: _____

PEDIATRIC SLEEP SPECIALIST (if needed)

Name: _____ Number: _____

FAMILY THERAPIST (if relevant)

Name: _____ Number: _____

US MATERNAL MENTAL HEALTH HOTLINE

1-833-852-6262 (also for parents in general struggle)

US PARENT STRESS LINE (Childhelp)

1-800-422-4453 (24/7, free, confidential)



From Soothemade Notes, a small apothecary of printables, planners, and cards for the unphotographed parts of new parenthood. Made slowly, in plain language.



Soothemade *Notes*

*Made for the version of you no one tells you about, the
one at four in the morning, the one in the parking lot, the
one who doesn't recognize her own week.*

notes.soothemade.com

Personal use only. Not for redistribution.
© 2026 Soothemade · made slowly, in plain language